was restricted to like-minded people and those who could be influenced. It was available on the internet, but full text could be accessed through membership recommended by another member.

Extensive use of the internet was an essential part of Al Qaeda's propaganda strategy. A report of Intelligence and Terrorism Information Center at the Israel Intelligence Heritage & Commemoration Center (IICC) commented, 'Bin Laden's intensive use of the Internet to spread his doctrines is productive and influences young Muslims, who adopt them and enlist in the global jihad in the various arenas in which it is taking place' (Intelligence & Terrorism Information Center, 2008). Moreover, it used the internet to create fear and give messages to various quarters, including the US authorities. On 7 May 2012, it released a video of the US citizen Warren Weinstein who was kidnapped from Lahore on 13 August 2011. According to the US monitoring service SITE, the 2-minute, 40-second video was posted on jihadist forums by al-Sahab. Through him, Al Qaeda demanded the release of 'Blind Sheikh' Omar Abdel-Rahman, Ramzi Yousef and El Sayyid Nosair, involved in the 1993 World Trade Center bombing, from US custody and the release of the family of Osama bin Laden (*Dawn*, 2012).

Pakistan experienced a media revolution in the mid-2000s. The introduction of private TV channels changed the trends of politics and terrorism. The Lal Masjid (Red Mosque) – Jamia Hafsa episode was telecasted live on TV channels, which unleashed a new era of extremism, militancy and terrorism in Pakistan. Media seemed sympathetic towards girls and young students holed up in the masjid and madrasah. It was also due to distrust and animosity against the then President of Pakistan General Pervez Musharraf. The chief cleric Abdul Rashid Ghazi, who later died in the exchange of fire with the security forces, had been interacting with the media via mobile phone during the military operation. This stirred the sensibilities of the audience and gave impetus to the suicide bombing in the coming months.

Conversely, another episode that changed the situation overnight against the militants of Swat was the video of a woman being flogged in Swat released to the media. It showed a girl made to lie upside down while two men held her hands and legs tightly and the third flogged her in front of a crowd. The girl cried and cringed with pain and shame. Viewers were deeply touched with these horrific scenes. It created an uproar and sparked hatred against the TTP in Swat, which